



# PRAYER

BERNARD JAMES

In Matthew 6:9-13 (NKJV), Jesus taught His disciples how to pray, and His teaching applies to us today.

There are six levels I want us to look at.

1. Praise
2. Priorities
3. Provision
4. Pardon
5. Protection
6. Praise Again

#### **Praise - Matthew 6:9**

When Jesus taught His disciples how to pray, His first focus was on entering the presence of His Father with His praise. *"Our Father in heaven, Hallowed (to make holy, revered as holy) be Your name."*

He drew attention to His Father by saying, "Our Father." You realize that He didn't say My Father. We must begin by praising God for being our Father, Jehovah-Jireh (Provider), Jehovah-Shalom (Peace), Jehovah-Rophe (Healer), Jehovah-Rohi (Shepherd), and we can go on and on. We come to our Father with the sacrifice of praise.

#### **Priorities - Matthew 6:10**

*"Your kingdom come. Your will be done on earth as it is in heaven."* We must focus on priorities, His priorities. We must set ourselves in agreement that His will be done today, in our homes, our families, our church family, and our job. Our prayer should be, Our Father, Your priorities are mine. Your will shall be done, whether I like it or not. I am led by Your peace, filled with Your joy and controlled by Your Holy Spirit.

#### **Provision - Matthew 6:11**

*"Give us this day our daily bread."* Our Father, You are our Jehovah-Jirah, our provider. Don't be ashamed to talk to our Father to tell Him, everything we have comes from You. I



don't have a thing You did not give me. You are a miracle-working God who provides all I need for today. Thank You for bringing the provision I need.

#### **Pardon - Matthew 6:12**

*"And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors."* Focus on God's pardon. Our Father, thank You for pardon, mercy and forgiveness. Because of You, I can gladly pardon and forgive all those who hurt and cause me harm in any way. Thank You also for allowing me to walk in love, and forgive in advance anyone who might have done anything wrong to me today, in Jesus' name.

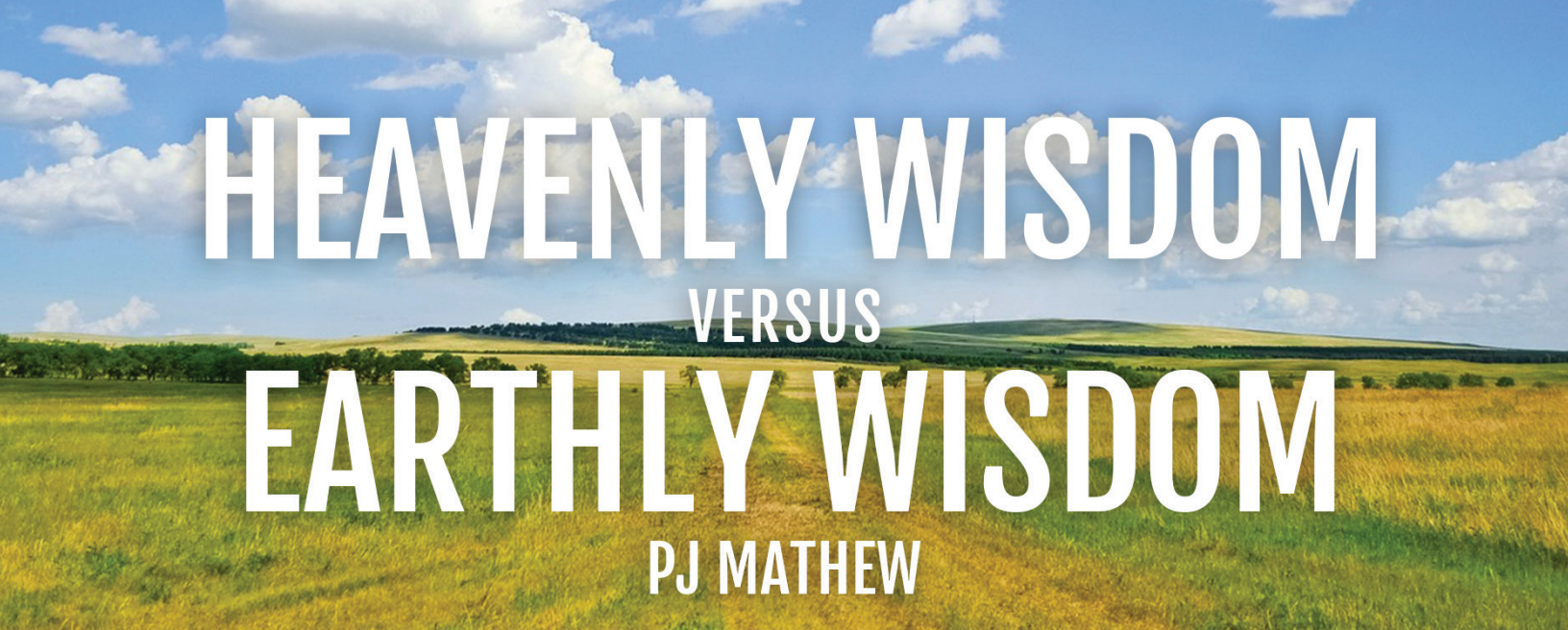
#### **Protection - Matthew 6:13**

*"And do not lead us into temptation, but deliver us from the evil one. For Yours is the kingdom and the power and*

*the glory forever. Amen."* Focus on God's protection. Our Father, guide us away from temptation and any trap planned to destroy our lives. Deliver us from the strategies designed to harm us in any way. Thank You for Your divine and angelic protection, in Jesus' name.

#### **Praise Again - Matthew 6:13**

Our Father, we praise You again for influencing our priorities, for Your provisions, for Your pardon of every sin, for Your protection from every evil work. Your praise shall continually be in our mouth. You are our Healer, our Deliver, our Savior, and Miracle-Worker. We know we can trust You completely, for You will not disappoint us. You have everything under Your control. The kingdom, the power and the glory, they all belong to You forever. In Jesus' name. Amen. ✝



# HEAVENLY WISDOM VERSUS EARTHLY WISDOM

## PJ MATHEW

Proverbs 9:10, *"The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is understanding."* This wisdom is not an ingenious plan but a heavenly plan for mankind. It is not a fear like a danger or anything like that, but a holy reverence for God. It is a hallowed fear of God. When we are overwhelmed with the fear of God, we say, I fear God and I will not do such a thing. This heavenly wisdom gives you inspiration for your faith and leads you to be steadfast in your walk with God. Apostle Paul prayed for the Ephesian church that they may receive the spirit of wisdom and revelation so that they may know Him (Christ) better (ref. Ephesians 1:17). Jesus exercised the gift of heavenly wisdom in many situations. In Matthew 21:23-27, we read how the chief priests and elders of the people came to Him and questioned His authority. Jesus answered using a word of wisdom and asked them a question. In Verse 24, He asked them whether the baptism of John was from heaven or of men. This word of wisdom stopped them from asking further questions. If they answered, "from heaven," He would ask why they didn't believe him. If they said, "It was from men,"

then the people would rise up against them because people believed that he was a prophet. Again in Matthew 22:15-22, Jesus answered the Herodians (Jewish supporters of the Herodian dynasty) with a word of wisdom. They asked Jesus whether it was lawful to give tribute to Caesar or not. Jesus asked them whose image and superscription is on the money. They answered, "Caesar's. Then He said unto them, *"Render therefore unto Caesar the things which are Caesar's and unto God the things which are of God"* (Matthew 22:21, KJV).

James 1:5, *"If any of you lacks wisdom, he should ask God, who gives generously to all without finding fault, and it will be given to him"* (NIV). Wisdom is entirely practical. It is not philosophical speculation and intellectual knowledge; it is concerned with the business of living. The stoics defined wisdom as "knowledge of things human and divine." J.H. Ropes defines this Christian wisdom as "the supreme and divine quality of the soul whereby man knows and practices righteousness." In Christian wisdom, there is, of course, knowledge of the deep things of God, but it is essentially

practical. It is such knowledge turned into action regarding the decisions and personal relationships of everyday life.

James 3:17-18, “*But the wisdom that comes from heaven is first of all pure; then peace loving, considerate, submissive, full of mercy and good fruit, impartial and sincere. Peacemakers who sow in peace raise a harvest of righteousness.*”

Purity: True wisdom thinks holy thoughts. It is cleansed from all ulterior motives. Such wisdom is so pure that we see God through purity. “*Blessed are the pure in heart for they shall see God*” (Matthew 5:8, NKJV).

Peace-loving: The true wisdom is *eirenikos* in Greek, which means peaceable. It is the right relationship between individuals and between individuals and God. There is a kind of clever and arrogant wisdom that separates people from one another, and which makes them look with superior contempt on others. At all times true wisdom brings people closer to one another and closer to God.

True wisdom is *epiekes* (gentle). The person who has *epiekes* speaks of someone who knows when it is actually wrong to apply the strict letter of the law. Such a person knows to forgive when strict justice dictates that there is a perfect right to condemn. Such a person knows when to make allowances, when not to stand upon individual rights, and how to soften justice with mercy and always remembers that there are greater things in the world than rules and regulations. It is the ability to extend the kind consideration we would ourselves wish to receive.

Submissive, *eupeithes* in Greek, means always ready to obey. A person who is *eupeithes* is always willing to obey God’s

voice. It also means easy to persuade, not in the sense of being pliable and weak, but in the sense of not being stubborn. It is being willing to listen to reason and wise counsel. True wisdom is not rigid but is willing to listen and skilled in knowing when wisely to yield.

Full of mercy, *eleos* in Greek, and good fruits: Here, wisdom is showing pity to those who are in trouble. Christian pity is the reflection of God’s pity that is shown to men and women not only when they were suffering unjustly, but also when they were suffering through their own fault. From a Christian perspective, *eleos* or pity produces good fruits which result in practical help. It is the Good Samaritan’s example (ref. Luke 10:30-35). Christian pity is not an emotion; it is an action.

Impartial or undivided, *adiakritos* in Greek, means not swaying or wavering. It knows its own mind, chooses its course and abides by it. Christian wisdom is based on Christian certainties which come to us from God through Jesus Christ.

Sincere, *anupokritos* in Greek, means without hypocrisy. That is to say, it is not a pretense and does not deal in deception. It is honest; it never pretends to be what it is not; and it never acts deceitfully to gain its own ends.

Finally, in the RSV translation, “*The harvest of righteousness is sown in peace by those who walk in peace*” (James 3:18). We cannot harvest righteousness if it is not sown in the right environment. In a place where bitterness, envy, and strife prevail, it is barren soil and the seeds of righteousness cannot grow there. For those who love to be in strife and bitterness, there is no reward for them at all. ✚

# BEING READY

## BRIAN HANNIGAN

A question was raised at the Pinelow, Washington camp, in 2023 about heads covered and uncovered in our church services. It was a good question that went something like this: “Why are men’s heads uncovered and women’s heads covered from the beginning of a service until the end? Why

don’t the men take off their hats for prayer and prophecy, and have women cover their heads at the same time?”

The apostolic brethren addressed this question early in this present move of the Holy Spirit.



1) We are to all be in a state of readiness when we gather. We come together *ready* to pray or prophesy at any time during the gathering of the church. Therefore, men uncover for the entire service and women cover to be ready to minister.

God, in those early years, began revealing to us from His Word that the church is many-membered. We are a gifted people. We prepare ourselves to minister by the prompting of the Holy Spirit even *before* the service begins.

2) The gathering of God's people is not ordinary; it is divine. It's holy ground. This is not man's arena. The church meets in heavenly places in Christ. It is God's realm, not ours. It is God who establishes how we conduct ourselves in His courts. We want to demonstrate our reverence for God. We cannot take this privilege lightly. When we examine the scriptures in 1 Corinthians 11:10, we are informed that the covering on a woman will invoke "power on her head because of the angels." Men covered in the same setting are showing dishonour to God. "Every man praying or prophesying, having his head covered, dishonours his head" (1 Corinthians 11:4).

These scriptures may leave us wondering *why* God wants heads covered and uncovered in the place of worship. But we are not left wondering how to obey. ✝

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